Town Crier Research Brief: Mariemont Soccer Coaches

Oct 14, 2026 · @Chase Beach

Overview

Chase is writing a tribute profile for the Mariemont Town Crier on coaches Erik Vanags and Jeff Hinebaugh, who are in their final season leading Mariemont High School boys soccer. The article is due November 1, 2026.

- **The angle:** a warm look back at their years coaching and what they mean to Mariemont, with Erik's teaching and Jeff's wider community role woven in.
- **Chase's connection:** Chase was Erik's student and was a freshman during Erik's first year teaching at Mariemont. Chase grew up in Mariemont and knows Jeff from the community.
- **First time:** this is Chase's first Town Crier piece and first formal interview, so the brief includes a prep checklist.
- **Who this brief is for:** Suzy Weinland, the Town Crier's editor, for feedback before the interviews.

Section 8 lists the facts to confirm before the interviews.

Erik Vanags: head coach and social studies teacher

Erik Vanags has been Mariemont's head boys soccer coach since 2012. He led the 2020 team to a 23-0 season and the program's first state title. Every source found spells his name **Erik** with a "k".

- **Teaching:** Social studies teacher at Mariemont High School (staff directory).
- **Arrival:** An older school bio says he came to Mariemont in 2007 after 10 years teaching and coaching at Milford, his alma mater. That page is now offline, and another source points to 2008. Chase's freshman year with him can confirm the year.
- **Before head coach:** Varsity assistant on the 2007 district title team and the 2008 State Final Four team (same old bio; verify with him).

- **2020 state title:** Beat Cardinal Mooney 4-1 in the Division III final on Nov. 14, 2020, at MAPFRE Stadium in Columbus. Luke Brothers scored twice, and Jimmy Sauter and Henry Buck once each (WKBN).
- **Coach of the Year:** Named 2020 OSSCA Division III Coach of the Year. Luke Brothers was Player of the Year (OSSCA all-Ohio list).
- **Career record:** About 194-66-26 for 2012–2025, added up from MaxPreps. MaxPreps can be incomplete, so ask him or the athletic office for the official number.
- **League:** Unbeaten in league play in 2013, 2015, 2016 and 2020. These are likely Cincinnati Hills League titles but aren't confirmed.
- **Recent seasons:** 15-5-1 in 2021, 16-3-1 in 2024, 18-3-1 in 2025.
- **The 2026 season so far:** 8-3-3 overall, 3-1-2 in the league, and ranked No. 13 in Ohio Division IV as of Oct. 14. Next is home against Finneytown on Oct. 15 at 7 p.m.; the tournament draw isn't posted yet (schedule).
- **Earlier coverage:** The Blueprint (student paper) and WCPO covered the 2020 run. No Town Crier or Enquirer profile was found.

Jeff Hinebaugh: assistant coach and community volunteer

Jeff Hinebaugh has been a varsity assistant coach at Mariemont since 2005, which would make 2026 his 22nd season. He has done it while working full time as a litigation partner.

- **Coaching:** Listed as varsity assistant coach on the school athletics site. He started in 2005, per his Dinsmore bio, which puts him on the bench for the 2007 district title, the 2008 Final Four and the 2020 state title.
- **Day job:** Partner in the litigation group at Dinsmore & Shohl in Cincinnati.
- **Education:** B.A. in accounting and history from Grove City College (1989, summa cum laude) and a J.D. from the University of Michigan (1992, cum laude). He also advises Grove City's men's soccer program on careers.
- **Mariemont ties:** Trustee of the Mariemont School Foundation. A Bloomberg profile also links him to the Mariemont Preservation Foundation (not yet confirmed).
- **Wider community:** Elder at Horizon Community Church, where he and his wife, Erika, have gone since 2000. They have two children. He is also a trustee of the Cincinnati Museum Center, Cincinnati Arts and Technology Studios, and Creative Aging Cincinnati.
- **Open question:** Did he play soccer, and where? None of the sources say. That's a good interview question.

What makes a great Town Crier article

Aim for 700–900 words with 2–3 captioned photos, and end on a memorable quote. A Nov. 1 deadline puts the story in the **December 2026 issue**.

The publication. The Town Crier is a free, volunteer-run monthly in its 51st year. It comes out September–December and February–May, and junior couriers deliver it to about 2,000 homes. Copy is due by 5 p.m. on the 1st of the month before the issue, sent to mariemonttowncrier@gmail.com. The editor is **Suzy Weinland**. Guidelines are sent on request; there's no current website, but past issues are on Issuu.

What strong past profiles look like

Article	Issue	Length	What it does well
"50 Years in the 'Mont" (Syd and Diane Sabo), by Suzy Weinland	Mar 2026	~850 words	Scene-setting opening, about 12 quotes, a 1952 photo next to a current one, ends on a striking quote
"From Brands to Classrooms: Thomas Gilmore", by Kim Beach	Sept 2025	~850 words	Career told through local impact; fun kicker about him yelling "LET'S GO MARIEMONT!" at games
"From Soccer to Siding: Greg Cochrane", by Kim Beach	Apr 2026	~650 words	Clear chronology; ends on "Mariemont is a utopia"
"John Getgey Left an Indelible Mark"	Feb 2026	~620 words	Memorial that touches on MHS athletics and his Hall of Fame induction
Janet Setchell, Outstanding Citizen, by Rosie Polter	Sept 2026	~430 words	Short news opening, then a career timeline and tribute quotes

The pattern to follow

1. **Headline** in "Title: subtitle" form, e.g. "Final Whistle: Vanags and Hinebaugh's Last Season on the Mariemont Sideline."
2. **Opening:** a scene (the 2020 final, or the two of them on the sideline today), not a summary.
3. **Background** in order, with exact years, places and records.

4. **Their own voices:** 8–12 quotes from the coaches, plus 2–3 from players, parents or colleagues.
5. **Mariemont details:** Kusel Stadium, the classroom, the School Foundation, local places.
6. **Ending** on their best quote, not a summary.
7. **Photos:** a 2020 state title photo with a current sideline shot, with "L-R" captions naming everyone. Ask whether Crier photographer Steve Spooner can shoot a game.

The Crier hasn't profiled either coach since at least Dec 2024, so this would be the first full feature. Issues from 2021–2024, including the 2020 title run, weren't checked.

Kim Beach's Resident Spotlight profiles are another good model for tone.

Interview questions

Ask for stories, not stats; the stats are in this brief. Questions marked with a star are the must-asks if time runs short.

For both, together

1. ★ How did the two of you end up coaching together, and what's your first memory of each other?
2. ★ Why is this the right time to step away?
3. What does each of you bring that the other doesn't?
4. ★ Take me back to the 2020 state final against Cardinal Mooney. What do you remember about that day?
5. That title came during COVID. What did that season mean to the town?
6. What has stayed the same about Mariemont soccer since 2005, and what has changed?
7. Is there a game, a player or a moment you still think about that most people would never know about?
8. What do you want the next coaches to keep?

For Erik

1. ★ Why did you leave Milford for Mariemont?
2. How does teaching social studies shape the way you coach, and the other way around?
3. What did you learn as an assistant in 2007 and 2008 that you used as head coach?
4. ★ What will you miss most: the classroom version of these kids or the field version?
5. Are you still teaching after this season?

6. (Personal) Do you remember Chase's freshman class? What was that first year at Mariemont like?

For Jeff

1. ★ Why does a busy litigation partner spend 20-plus falls coaching high school soccer?
2. Did you play? Where, and what position?
3. How has being a lawyer made you a better coach, or the reverse?
4. ★ What does Mariemont mean to you beyond soccer, with the School Foundation and everything else?
5. What's next for you after the final whistle?

Outside voices (3–5 minutes each)

- A current senior: What will you remember about playing for them?
- A 2020 state champion (Luke Brothers, Jimmy Sauter, Kyle Croll or a teammate): What did they teach you that you still use?
- A parent or the athletic director: What have they given this program that doesn't show in the record?

Wrap-up for everyone: What didn't I ask that I should have? Can you double-check the spelling of every name you mentioned?

Interview locations

The plan: interview both coaches together on the team bench at Kusel Stadium for memories and photos, ideally before a practice on a non-game day. Then do the one-on-ones back to back at Southerby's, about 20–30 minutes each, at a quiet hour. Call ahead to confirm it's open.

Location	Best for	Watch out for
Tom Crosby Field at Kusel Stadium	Photos of both coaches on their home field; memories come easily there	Wind and noise on a recording; go before or after practice, not on game day
Practice field	Shows them at work; possible quick quotes from players	Busy during practice; name not found online, so ask the athletic office

Location	Best for	Watch out for
Southerby's Pub, Mariemont Inn, 6880 Wooster Pike	Quiet and cozy, in the heart of the village; a classic Mariemont setting	Limited hours (some listings say Wed–Sat from 4 p.m.), so call ahead

Fit the schedule around the tournament. Avoid game days, and offer to wait until their season ends if they'd rather. That still leaves time before Nov. 1 only if the season ends early, so aim for Friday, Oct. 23.

Timeline and interview checklist

Chase plans to interview the coaches on Friday, October 23. **Note:** Chase is out of town Sunday, Oct. 18 through Thursday, Oct. 22, so Friday, Oct. 23 is the first open day. The week of Oct. 26 is the backup, but it leaves only a few days to write before the Nov. 1 deadline.

1. **Oct 14–16:** Share this brief with Suzy and confirm the word count, photo needs, submission format and exact due time.
2. **Oct 15–17:** Reach out to Erik and Jeff to set up the interviews before leaving town on Oct. 18. Offer 45–60 minutes, together or separately.
3. **Fri, Oct 23 (or the week of Oct 26):** Do the interviews. Add 2–3 short calls with a current player, a parent or a former player for outside voices.
4. **By Oct 26:** Transcribe the recordings, highlight the best quotes, and outline the story.
5. **Oct 27–29:** Write the draft. Check every name, date, record and title.
6. **Oct 30:** Send the draft to Suzy for a read. If needed, double-check facts (not wording) with the coaches.
7. **Oct 31:** Make final edits and submit with photos, a day early.

First-interview checklist

- [ ] Ask permission to record, then record on your phone and also take short notes.
- [ ] Bring a printed list of questions, but follow the conversation.
- [ ] Start with easy questions, then go to the bigger ones.
- [ ] Ask open questions ("Tell me about…", "What was it like when…").
- [ ] Follow up with "Can you give me an example?" and let silences sit.
- [ ] Confirm name spellings, titles, years and records on the spot.
- [ ] Ask for photos (old team photos, action shots) and who should get photo credit.

- [ ] Close with "What didn't I ask that I should have?"
- [ ] Send a thank-you text the same day.

Facts to verify and sources

Confirm these with the coaches or the athletic office before anything goes to print.

- [ ] **Final season:** No public announcement was found. Confirm that both are stepping down and that it's OK to say so in print.
- [ ] **Erik's first year at Mariemont:** 2007 or 2008? Check Chase's freshman year.
- [ ] **Jeff's start year:** 2005, per his law firm bio.
- [ ] **Official career record:** About 194-66-26 from MaxPreps, 2012–2025.
- [ ] **League titles:** Were 2013, 2015, 2016 and 2020 Cincinnati Hills League championships?
- [ ] **2007 district title and 2008 Final Four:** Erik's role as assistant.
- [ ] **Practice field:** its official name.
- [ ] **Jeff and the Mariemont Preservation Foundation:** current role?
- [ ] **Town Crier specs:** word count and photo requirements from Suzy.

Sources

- MaxPreps: Mariemont soccer history, 2026 schedule, staff
- Mariemont Schools staff directory
- Mariemont Athletics: Jeff Hinebaugh
- Dinsmore & Shohl: Jeffrey P. Hinebaugh
- Horizon Community Church: Jeff Hinebaugh
- WKBN: 2020 state final
- OSSCA 2020 Division III all-Ohio list
- The Blueprint, 2020
- Tom Crosby Field at Kusel Stadium
- Mariemont Town Crier on Issuu and the Village Town Crier page
- Southerby's Pub, Fifty West Brewing
- Interviewing tips: Poynter, before, during and after an interview, Poynter, Banaszynski's tips